

st

nam, 43

S, an
kes
n. She
to the
n jamaat
districts

er mother
e she taught
nt

or Muslim
ntry is
t
ational

being subjugated under the triple talaq, which had become valid when communicated over the phone or even via e-mail. The 1990s, which saw widespread communal violence by right-wing groups, sometimes at the state's behest, made her think again about her relationship with Islam. Brought up as a believer, she decided to call herself a radical feminist. "I did not expect such a response from my brethren. I wanted to sensitise them about their basic human rights. But once they had savoured freedom, the women asked me to give them real power," she says.

Located in the state's Pudukkottai district, STEPS's task of organising Muslim women often took her to remote areas in Tamil Nadu. But the effort has borne fruit. STEPS has, till now, helped more than 10,000 women. It has assisted in resolving a number of cases relating to marital disputes and dowry as well as sexual abuse. It has helped settle destitute women and provided employment to several women. "The main objective of STEPS is to develop women's self-confidence and help them to live with self-respect and dignity," says the brave woman.

She cites the example of the 35-year-old

Rajitha, whose husband had an extra marital affair and after complaining to the local jamaat, divorced her. The couple had a 13-year-old daughter. The jamaat had then sent Rajitha a notice to take Rs 1 lakh as alimony and leave her husband's home. The local police could do nothing to help the hapless woman. It was then that she approached Khanam, who took up the case with the Sivaganga jamaat, where the clerics were already against her. They did not listen to Khanam's repeated requests and she was forced to approach the local police station yet again, asking them to register the case under the new women's law. Today, Rajitha is living in her husband's home with her daughter, though he has left her. But Khanam is happy to have been able to provide her some financial security.

Khanam is a satisfied woman, almost. Despite the threats from Muslim clerics, she has come a long way and has been able to set up women jamaats in 15 of the 31 districts in Tamil Nadu. These jamaats now boast of more than 25,000 members. The women meet once every month to discuss the issues and problems that lie ahead of them. But even after four years, Khanam

still faces opposition from the community clerics, who have dubbed her anti-Islamic. But that has never and will never deter her. "I am not aiming for a religious fight with them. We approach the men to solve the issues of women who come to us. If they don't agree, we go to the police," she says.

The construction of the all-woman mosque has temporarily been stopped due to lack of money. Khanam has already spent Rs 10 lakh from her own savings and from whatever little contributions the women members of the jamaat could make. And though she needs another Rs 50 lakh for the completion of the project, Khanam who is married to Rahmed, a businessman, could not be more motivated. Her mother has been her constant source of inspiration, and after her passing away, her role has been taken over by her elder sister Humera Khanam. She has only one mission and she thinks it is possible. "All I want is my mosque to become the nerve centre of a vibrant, Islamic, feminist and democratic culture," she says proudly. Inshallah. ■

